

« BEFORE

Soviet dictator Joseph Stalin's death in March 1953 led to a temporary thaw in the Cold War.

PEACE WINDOW

Improved relations between Soviet leaders and the United States and its allies led to an armistice that halted the fighting in the Korean War in July 1953. French setbacks in the **First Indochina War**, culminating in their defeat at **Dien Bien Phu** in May 1954, then led France to seek a settlement with the Viet Minh.



JOSEPH STALIN LYING IN STATE

At a meeting held in Berlin in January and February 1954, representatives of the Soviet Union, Britain, the United States, and France agreed to convene an international conference in Geneva to negotiate peace settlements in Korea and Indochina. The United States consented to communist China's invitation to the conference, although they refused to recognize the legitimacy of Mao Zedong's regime. The State of Vietnam, set up by France in 1949, was represented, as was Ho Chi Minh's Democratic Republic of Vietnam, although it was not recognized as legitimate by the Western powers.

The Geneva Conference opened in April 1954. Negotiations on Korea achieved nothing, with the result that it continued to be regulated by the terms of the ceasefire agreed the previous year. The question of Indochina was more urgent. Fighting continued even while the delegates convened. The French defeat at Dien Bien Phu in the first week of May was followed by another military disaster in June, when the Viet Minh annihilated Groupe Mobile 100 at An Khe.

France either had to find a peace deal or escalate the war by drafting high numbers of conscripted troops into Vietnam. The situation threw the French government into crisis. On June 18, Pierre Mendès-France, a politician who had long advocated a negotiated settlement with the Viet Minh, was appointed prime minister of France. He promised to achieve a peace deal within a month or resign.